

Plant Fest 2026 — Full Event Data Dump

FishKeepingLifeCo | Raw Observations, Reflections, and Ecosystem Notes

This document compiles all major observations, reflections, themes, and experiences from visiting Plant Fest 2026 hosted by Fitz's Fish Ponds. The focus is on documenting the event experience, ecosystem observations, hobby crossover, and long-form discussion points for future content creation.

Initial Expectations vs Reality

- Expected a traditional aquarium expo with multiple vendors and aquascaping booths
- Actual event was an open-house style experience hosted entirely by Fitz's Fish Ponds
- More focused on koi ponds, aquatic plants, greenhouse systems, and outdoor ecosystems
- Event felt community-oriented and educational rather than commercial

Arrival and Event Logistics

- Parking was located off-site
- Attendees were shuttled onto the property
- Check-in included registration scanning and raffle ticket distribution
- The event itself was completely free to attend
- Raffles were held throughout the day
- Guest speakers rotated through presentations

General Atmosphere

- Relaxed and exploratory environment
- Mixture of pond hobbyists, aquarium hobbyists, and plant enthusiasts
- Older koi pond crowd mixed with younger planted tank hobbyists
- Social media likely helped attract younger aquarium hobbyists

Koi Pond Observations

- Large koi ponds throughout the property
- Healthy koi with some fish reaching prices in the thousands of dollars
- Visible plumbing and infrastructure added educational value
- Rotating drum filters and chillers visible in operation
- Large-scale filtration systems demonstrated ecosystem management principles at scale

Greenhouses and Aquatic Plants

- Multiple greenhouse structures filled with lotus plants, lilies, floating plants, and aquatic vegetation
- Large-scale aquatic gardening connected naturally to planted tank concepts
- Plants reinforced the ecosystem-focused atmosphere of the event
- Bonsai tree section reflected patience and long-term cultivation philosophy

Aquarium Plant Displays

- Submerged aquatic plant section inside the store
- Two 40-gallon breeder tanks used for display and plant sales
- Presence of visually impressive red aquatic plants
- Interesting seeing higher-demand plants in relatively simple systems

Shrimp Bowl Displays

- Several planted glass bowls displayed inside the store
- One setup included red cherry shrimp
- Minimal setups using plants, substrate, shrimp, and hardscape
- No fish and very minimal visible equipment
- Demonstrated how visually engaging small ecosystem-style systems can be
- Represented simplicity and biological balance

Equipment and Industry Observations

- Strong presence of Oase filtration products
- Pond filtration and water management systems heavily featured
- Some attendees recognized premium aquarium brands like Chihiros lighting
- Showed overlap between high-end aquarium hobbyists and pond keepers

Beginner Hobbyist Observations

- Overheard beginner questions about aquasoil and planted tank setups
- Many beginner questions mirrored pond hobby concerns
- Common questions centered around filtration, plant growth, stability, and maintenance
- Highlighted how connected pond keeping and aquarium keeping really are

Personal Reflections

- The same ecosystem principles apply across ponds, aquariums, and shrimp bowls
- Scale changes, but core biological concepts remain similar
- Plants, filtration, nutrient management, and stability connect all aquatic systems
- Event broadened perspective on the aquatic hobby as a whole

29-Gallon Ecosystem Balance Project

- Considered purchasing additional aquatic plants but decided against it
- Current focus is reducing maintenance and minimizing water changes
- Goal is long-term system stability through reduced intervention
- Trying to avoid changing variables while observing tank maturity
- Reinforced philosophy that sometimes systems improve when left alone

Carnivorous Plants Purchase

- Purchased a Sarracenia pitcher plant

- Purchased a Drosera sundew
- Discussion about using aquarium water versus distilled water
- Staff recommended distilled water for carnivorous plants
- Interesting connection between aquatic systems, nutrient sensitivity, and plant care

Major Themes and Takeaways

- Aquarium keeping and pond keeping are deeply interconnected
 - Ecosystem thinking applies across all scales
 - Simple systems can still be biologically rich and visually impressive
 - The hobby extends beyond glass aquariums into ponds, gardening, greenhouse growing, and nature-focused cultivation
 - Long-term patience and observation remain central to successful systems
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Final Reflection:

Plant Fest 2026 became less about covering an event and more about observing how all corners of the aquatic hobby intersect — from koi ponds and greenhouse systems to shrimp bowls and planted tanks. The event reinforced the idea that regardless of scale, aquatic hobbyists are all exploring the same larger themes: stability, biology, plants, water, and long-term ecosystem balance.